

Analyzing the media strategies of ModCloth, Gymshark, Victoria Beckham, and Fashion Nova reveals a masterclass in modern e-commerce performance. While they sell very different aesthetics, their underlying technical approach to images and video is highly strategic and optimized for mobile-first conversions.

Here is a breakdown of the aspect ratios, sizes, and formats these top-tier brands use to maintain visual quality without destroying their page load speeds.

1. The Aspect Ratios (The Shape of the Image)

Apparel e-commerce has almost entirely abandoned the square (1:1) image. Because humans are taller than they are wide, using squares wastes valuable screen real estate.

- **The "Social Commerce" Ratio (3:4 or 4:5):** Fashion Nova and Gymshark lean heavily into this. It mimics the Instagram and TikTok feed experience. A 3:4 ratio takes up maximum vertical space on a mobile phone, allowing the user to see the full outfit, but it leaves just enough room at the bottom of the screen for the "Add to Cart" button to remain visible without scrolling.
- **The "Editorial" Ratio (2:3):** Victoria Beckham, operating in the high-end luxury space, uses a taller 2:3 ratio. This mimics the proportions of a high-fashion magazine page (like *Vogue*). It allows for dramatic, artistic full-body shots, though it requires careful UI design to ensure buttons aren't pushed below the fold on smaller screens.
- **The "Standard Catalog" Ratio (3:4):** ModCloth utilizes a clean 3:4 ratio. This provides a consistent grid that focuses heavily on lifestyle and approachable fashion without the hyper-tall editorial crop.

2. Upload Dimensions vs. Display Dimensions

A major misconception is that these sites upload one image size and serve it to everyone. They don't. They use responsive imagery (srcset in HTML).

- **The Base Upload (For Zooming):** Photographers for these brands upload very large, high-resolution files. Industry standards, such as those discussed in optimization guides for sites like ModCloth, suggest base images should be between 1000px to 1600px on the longest side. Anything smaller ruins the "Hover to Zoom" functionality, and anything larger unnecessarily burdens the server.
- **The Display Sizes:** The server (usually a CDN like Cloudinary or Shopify's image API) automatically generates multiple sizes on the fly:
 - **Mobile Grid:** ~400px to 600px wide.
 - **Desktop Grid:** ~800px wide.
 - **Main Product Page Image:** ~1200px wide.

3. File Sizes and Formats (The Speed Secret)

If you inspect the network tab on Gymshark or Fashion Nova, you will rarely see a .jpg or .png

being served to the browser.

- **Modern Formats:** They use **WebP** or **AVIF** formats. These modern formats maintain the visual quality of a JPEG but at roughly half the file size.
- **Target File Sizes:**
 - **Grid Thumbnails:** 30KB – 70KB.
 - **Hero/Main Images:** 100KB – 200KB.

4. Video Specifications (The Conversion Driver)

Fashion Nova and Gymshark use video aggressively to sell the fit and movement of the garment. Getting video to autoplay smoothly in a grid of 20 products requires strict constraints.

- **The Autoplay Grid Video:**
 - **Format:** Highly compressed MP4 (H.264) or WebM.
 - **Duration:** 3 to 6 seconds (seamlessly looped).
 - **File Size Goal:** Strictly under **1.5MB to 2MB**.
 - **Audio:** The audio track is completely stripped from the file prior to upload. Muting a video via HTML still downloads the audio data; stripping it saves massive amounts of bandwidth.
- **The Product Page Video:**
 - These can be longer (15–30 seconds) and higher quality (1080p vertical), usually hovering around **5MB to 8MB**.

Summary Matrix

Brand Archetype	Primary Aspect Ratio	Vibe & UI Strategy
Fast Fashion (Fashion Nova)	3:4 or 4:5	Instagram-style, aggressive visual density.
Activewear (Gymshark)	3:4	High-energy, movement, focus on athletic fit.
Luxury (Victoria Beckham)	2:3	Editorial, magazine-style, ample white space.
Vintage (ModCloth)	3:4	Approachable, clear catalog presentation.